My positive and optimistic approach and attitude had a lot to do with my spiritual beliefs. It was not about going to the temple or praying every morning, or performing some rituals, but trying to be a good human being, someone who is constantly in touch with his faith. Due to this, I could not be subjugated by doubt, despite the challenges and rough weather I went through. For a soldier, and an officer in particular, faith is a personal issue and hence should play no part in his or her official work.

At times, on seeing some very high-ranking officers looking morose and unhappy over small or mundane matters, I would remind them of the high office they were occupying, and all that the organization had given to them. And also advise them to recast their definition of happiness or redraw the 'lakshman rekhas' (limits) of their desires, and be content in life. It is much better to be a happy colonel rather than an unhappy general, I would reiterate to them! In my view, this only happens to those officers who become 'rats' in the rat race, instead of being 'tigers'. They live their entire careers trying to ensure the happiness of their bosses instead of their own, and then keep complaining. I have always maintained that success and happiness are products of many factors, and as in any mathematical equation, a zero multiplied with any number makes the total 'zero'. For example, if one's son becomes a drug addict, or the daughter elopes with someone undesirable, or the wife ends up as a nervous wreck, is the next rank worth it? Success at what cost! One comes across both categories of officers amongst the serving and veteran fraternity. Fortunately, there are more happy guys, but some amongst the senior lot are fairly disgruntled too.

'What do I treasure most from my life's experience?' was a question once posed to me. 'The affection, trust and devotion that I received from my officers and men in arms whom I had the proud privilege to command is something that is priceless and I was fortunate to get it and hence, value it the most,' was my answer. And now, in my new assignment, which I call the second innings, I am striving to achieve the sobriquet of a 'people's governor'. I consider that for